

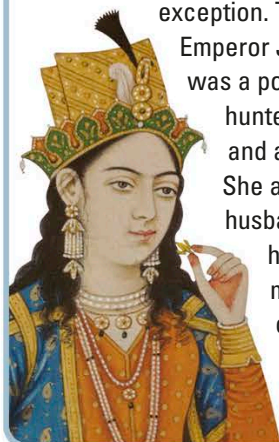
The Mughal Empire

When a warlord from Central Asia named Babur invaded northern India in the early 1520s, he set the stage for one of the greatest empires the world had ever seen. Over the next 300 years, the Mughal Empire he established conquered much of modern-day Afghanistan, Pakistan, India, and Bangladesh. By the 18th century, however, Mughal power had begun to decline.

Armed with matchlocks (early guns) and powerful cannons, Babur and his army had arrived in India searching for a new kingdom. He overthrew the unpopular Lodhi Sultanate in Delhi in 1526 and established the rule of the Mughals. After Babur's initial victories, his descendants extended their empire across much of the Indian subcontinent.

NUR JAHAN

Royal women did not hold much power in the Mughal court, but Nur Jahan (1577–1645), was an exception. The wife of Emperor Jahangir, she was a poet, a skilled hunter, a diplomat, and an art lover. She advised her husband and might have even made political decisions on Jahangir's behalf.



Under the Mughals, Islamic art and culture flourished. Many of the grandest monuments still standing in India and Pakistan today date from Mughal times.

After the death of the sixth Mughal emperor Aurangzeb in 1707, the empire began to crumble. Shivaji, ruler of the rival Marathas, was the first to defeat the Mughal armies. Then came the East India Company, a powerful British trading corporation, with its own private army. The British slowly grabbed territory as their own until they overthrew the last Mughal emperor in 1857.

FACT

The official language of the Mughal court was Persian. Arabic was used for religious prayer and ceremonies while Urdu came to be spoken by the intellectual elites, poets, and saints.



◀ MUGHAL ARCHITECTURE

The Mughals built many majestic forts and beautiful tombs. Made of red sandstone and white marble, Humayun's Tomb in Delhi is one of their most elegant early monuments. Its architectural style, with domes and arches, was copied in later buildings, such as the magnificent Taj Mahal, a tomb built by Shah Jahan for his wife Mumtaz Mahal.

MAJOR EMPERORS

1526–1530

After defeating the last Sultan of Delhi at the first Battle of Panipat, Babur goes on to gain more territory in northern India. But his rule is unstable, and when he dies he leaves a kingdom of fighting tribes.

1530–1556

Soon after taking the throne, Babur's son Humayun loses much of his kingdom and is forced into exile in Persia. After 15 years, he reclaims his empire with the help of the Persians, but dies within a year of doing so.

1556–1605

Akbar is considered the greatest Mughal emperor. He restores Mughal rule in the territories lost by his father, promotes art and culture, and encourages harmony between Hindus and Muslims.